

The Revolt of "Mother"

Mary E. Wilkins Freeman · 1890

First published: Harper's Bazar, Sep 1890

TEACHER EDITION · CURRICULUM UNIT

Common Core edition (standards shown for this framework only)

One 90-minute lesson (the whole story), with an optional take-home essay

Syllabus · 90-minute lesson plans · lecture scripts · vocabulary · quizzes with keys · writing prompts at eleven rigor levels · SAT-style items · whole-book test · essays

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Contents and unit overview

1. Unit overview and the 90-minute lesson
2. Syllabus (weekly pacing)
3. Lesson 1: introduction (author, context, reception, overview)
4. Lesson plans and lecture scripts (chapters 1–1), each with vocabulary, discussion questions, annotation focus, quiz and key, writing prompts and SAT-style items
5. Unit test (eleven rigor versions) with answer keys and scoring guides
6. Final paper
7. Essay assignments at eleven rigor levels

Edition: Reading text: https://en.wikisource.org/wiki/A_New_England_Nun_and_Other_Stories/The_Revolt_of_"Mother" (revision 14965993), cleaned for Liber et Libri.

Grades: Grades 9–12 (accessible text, well suited to the scaffolded-support track; scales to graduate via rigor levels). Short story: read whole in one 90-minute lesson (assign longer stories as pre-reading). The scaffolded-support track works from the full text with scaffolds. **Weeks:** 1. **Class days:** 2 × 90 minutes (1 chapter lessons plus seminar, test and essay days).

Essential questions

- What does The Revolt of "Mother" suggest about women's rights in marriage?
- What does The Revolt of "Mother" suggest about home and dignity?
- What does The Revolt of "Mother" suggest about quiet rebellion?

Objectives

- Students will cite at least 2 quotations, with locations, to support each written claim about what the text says explicitly and implicitly (scored on the writing-prompt rubric).
- Students will trace one theme across at least 3 sections of the story in the final paper, earning at least 70 of 100 rubric points.
- Students will explain how characters, setting and point of view interact in at least 3 exit tickets, each meeting the claim-evidence-reasoning criteria.
- Students will determine the in-context meaning of taught vocabulary, scoring at least 80% on the vocabulary items of the story quizzes.
- Students will write an argument with a clear claim, reasons and relevant evidence, scoring at least 80% on the unit test's short-answer scoring guides.

Standards: Common Core

RL.9-10.1, RL.9-10.2, RL.9-10.3, RL.9-10.4, RL.9-10.5, RL.11-12.1, RL.11-12.2, RL.11-12.4, RL.11-12.5, W.9-10.1, W.11-12.1, L.9-10.4, L.11-12.4

Common Core State Standards (ELA-Literacy), thecorestandards.org

Assessments: Daily story quizzes (auto-graded); Weekly writing prompt (rubric); Socratic seminars (scheduled days); Whole-story test (scheduled day); Final essay (scheduled day); College Sophomore and above write one essay of the five
Differentiation: Every prompt and quiz has eleven rigor levels (Scaffolded support through Graduate / PhD); the app applies student override, then class standard, then the automatic level. Each prompt is tagged for Common Core, Indiana 2023, Dual Credit (Indiana College Core), AP and Cambridge where they apply.
Materials: Liber et Libri reader; Annotation journal; Story lecture slides or script

The 90-minute lesson

#	Segment	Mode	Minutes	Clock
1	Bell-ringer	You do	8	0–8
2	Vocabulary with etymology notes	I do	10	8–18
3	Background and context	I do	10	18–28
4	I do: modeled close reading	I do	12	28–40
5	We do: guided annotation	We do	15	40–55
6	You do: independent annotation	You do	15	55–70
7	Discussion	We do	10	70–80
8	Exit ticket / chapter quiz	You do	7	80–87
9	Closure	I do	3	87–90
	Total		**90**	

Syllabus

Week	Chapters	Lessons	Focus and activities	Assessment
1	*Introduction: author, context and reception* The Revolt of "Mother"	2 × 90 min (180 min)	*women's rights in marriage* • Daily 90-minute lesson: bell-ringer, vocabulary and word histories, background, I do / We do / You do, discussion, exit ticket, closure • Story quizzes in the app • Introduction: author, context and reception • Writing prompt at assigned rigor (one graded per week)	Quiz average plus one graded writing prompt

Lesson plans and lecture scripts

Each chapter is one 90-minute class. Scripts are a starting point; adapt them to your students. Teacher summaries contain spoilers.

Lesson 1: Introduction to The Revolt of "Mother"

Objective: Students will explain, in a 3-sentence exit ticket, how one fact about Mary E. Wilkins Freeman's life or times connects to women's rights in marriage in “The Revolt of "Mother"”, and will set up a reading journal with a prediction and a question for each of 3 themes (women's rights in marriage, home and dignity, quiet rebellion).

Standards: Common Core RL.9-10.1, RL.9-10.2

Author biography

Mary E. Wilkins Freeman was born in Randolph, Massachusetts, on 31 October 1852 and grew up in Randolph and Brattleboro, Vermont. After her parents' deaths left her with little money, she supported herself by writing; her collections A Humble Romance (1887) and A New England Nun (1891) portray the lives, especially women's lives, of small New England villages. In 1926 she received the William Dean Howells Medal for fiction. She died on 13 March 1930.

Historical and cultural context

Set in rural New England in the late nineteenth century, when farm wives had no legal claim to family property and few public voices. The title echoes the Revolution of 1776.

Publication and reception, then and now

First published in Harper's New Monthly Magazine in September 1890; collected in A New England Nun and Other Stories (1891).

Then: Very popular; Freeman later wrote that it was unrealistic.

Now: Taught for its feminist themes and local colour.

Overview (spoiler-free)

Sarah Penn learns that her husband Adoniram is building a new barn on the spot where, forty years before, he had promised to build her a new house.

Main themes

- women's rights.
- marriage and communication.
- quiet rebellion.

Why it matters

It shows quiet, persistent resistance and invites comparisons to modern equality debates.

Spoilers · teacher only

While Adoniram is away, Sarah moves the family into the barn; he returns, is astonished, and agrees to fit it up as a house.

Lesson plan (90 minutes)

0–8 min · Bell-ringer · You do (8 min)
Students write to the bell-ringer, then pair-share.
Before we open The Revolt of "Mother": How do you stand up for yourself without shouting?
Prompt: Before we open The Revolt of "Mother": How do you stand up for yourself without shouting?

8–18 min · Key terms · I do (10 min)
Key literary terms for the unit.
local colour; dialect; characterization; allusion.

18–28 min · Mini-lecture: author, context, reception · I do (10 min)
Mini-lecture on the author, the historical context and the reception (read or adapt the script).
About the author. Mary E. Wilkins Freeman was born in Randolph, Massachusetts, on 31 October 1852 and grew up in Randolph and Brattleboro, Vermont. After her parents' deaths left her with little money, she supported herself by writing; her collections A Humble Romance (1887) and A New England Nun (1891) portray the lives, especially women's lives, of small New England villages. In 1926 she received the William Dean Howells Medal for fiction. She died on 13 March 1930. The world of the book. Set in rural New England in the late nineteenth century, when farm wives had no legal claim to family property and few public voices. The title echoes the Revolution of 1776. Publication and reception. First published in Harper's New Monthly Magazine in September 1890; collected in A New England Nun and Other Stories (1891). Then: Very popular; Freeman later wrote that it was unrealistic. Now: Taught for its feminist themes and local colour.

28–40 min · I do: the book in one passage · I do (12 min)
Model a close reading of one passage using the written think-aloud below.
First, meaning. I read "I hadn't no idee you was so set on't as all this comes to" slowly and put it in my own words: Adoniram says he had no idea she was so set on this. Next, craft. I notice dialect and plain words, which make him sound honest and humbled. The strongest word is "idee": the spelling captures his rural voice and his surprise. Then, effect. What does Adoniram's line reveal at the end? My answer: He finally sees his wife's needs after forty years; the line shows the "revolt" has changed him.

> *I hadn't no idee you was so set on't as all this comes to (The Revolt of "Mother", paragraph 166)*

Think-aloud: First, meaning. I read "I hadn't no idee you was so set on't as all this comes to" slowly and put it in my own words: Adoniram says he had no idea she was so set on this. Next, craft. I notice dialect and plain words, which make him sound honest and humbled. The strongest word is "idee": the spelling captures his rural voice and his surprise. Then, effect. What does Adoniram's line reveal at the end? My answer: He finally sees his wife's needs after forty years; the line shows the "revolt" has changed him.

40–55 min · We do: overview and themes · We do (15 min)
Read the spoiler-free overview together and name the themes to track.
What the book is about (no spoilers): Sarah Penn learns that her husband Adoniram is building a new barn on the spot where, forty years before, he had promised to build her a new house. Themes to track: women's rights.: marriage and communication.: quiet rebellion.:

55–70 min · You do: reading journal · You do (15 min)
Set up a reading journal: one page per theme, with a prediction and a question (example given).
Set up a reading journal: one page per theme with a prediction and a question. Example page. Theme: women's rights. Prediction: I expect this idea to be tested when a character has to choose between what they want and what others expect. Question: what will The Revolt of "Mother" suggest about women's rights by the end?
Task: Set up a reading journal for The Revolt of "Mother": one page per theme, each with a prediction and a question.
Exemplar: Example page. Theme: women's rights. Prediction: I expect this idea to be tested when a character has to choose between what they want and what others expect. Question: what will The Revolt of "Mother" suggest about women's rights by the end?

70–80 min · Discussion · We do (10 min)
Whole-class discussion: why the book is still taught.
Why does The Revolt of "Mother" still matter? It shows quiet, persistent resistance and invites comparisons to modern equality debates.
Anchor question: Why might The Revolt of "Mother" still be taught today?
Facilitation: It shows quiet, persistent resistance and invites comparisons to modern equality debates.

80–87 min · Exit ticket · You do (7 min)
Exit ticket on the author and context (answer given).
Freeman lived in rural New England and wrote local-color stories for magazines in the 1880s and 1890s. What did she want readers to notice about rural women's lives? Answer: Accept answers such as: hard work and little say in family decisions; quiet strength; how small acts could be bold.
Exit ticket: Freeman lived in rural New England and wrote local-color stories for magazines in the 1880s and 1890s. What did she want readers to notice about rural women's lives?
Answer: Accept answers such as: hard work and little say in family decisions; quiet strength; how small acts could be bold.

87–90 min · Closure · I do (3 min)
Preview the first reading.
Tomorrow we begin reading: The Revolt of "Mother".

Teacher notes · sources: Britannica, "Mary E. Wilkins Freeman" (https://www.britannica.com/biography/Mary-E-Wilkins-Freeman); Mary E. Wilkins Freeman, A New England Nun and Other Stories (1891) (https://www.gutenberg.org/)

Flags (verify before teaching):

- Sources differ on the first venue: our story metadata says Harper's Bazar, while many anthologies cite Harper's New Monthly Magazine (September 1890). Verify before printing.
- Freeman later criticized the story as unrealistic; this is usually traced to her 1917 Saturday Evening Post essay "Who's Who—and Why." Verify before quoting.

Lesson 2: The Revolt of "Mother"

Focus: a wife's quiet rebellion for a decent home

Objective: Students will analyze how characterization develops in “The Revolt of "Mother"” by writing a claim-evidence-reasoning paragraph that cites at least 2 quotations from the section, and will score at least 80% on the section quiz.

Standards: Common Core RL.9-10.3, W.9-10.1, L.9-10.4

Content note (): No significant sensitive content flagged; preview as usual.
Student preview: Nothing in this story needs a special warning.
Suggested language: “Why does the writer include this, and what does it make us notice?”

Teacher only · spoilers

For forty years Sarah Penn has waited for the new house her husband Adoniram promised. Instead he builds another barn. While he is away buying a horse, she moves the family and furniture into the new barn and makes it a home. Adoniram returns, is stunned, and weeps, saying he will put up partitions and windows: he never knew she was so set on it.

Background: Published in Harper's Bazar in 1890. Freeman wrote about rural New England, where farm wives had little legal say over property.

Significance: A regionalist story about a woman's independence; often paired with A Jury of Her Peers and The Story of an Hour.

Lesson plan and lecture script (90 minutes)

0–8 min · Bell-ringer · You do (8 min)
Students write to the bell-ringer, then pair-share.
How can someone stand up for themselves without shouting? Write for five minutes. Starters: I think... because... / This connects to quiet rebellion because.... Content note before we start: Nothing in this story needs a special warning.
Prompt: How can someone stand up for themselves without shouting?
Sentence starters: I think… because… · This connects to quiet rebellion because…
Strong response: A strong response takes a position and anticipates this: she acts rather than argues.

8–18 min · Vocabulary with etymology notes · I do (10 min)
Five key words in context, with verified word histories.
Today's words: sedulous — careful and persistent; scuttled — ran with short quick steps; inspecting — looking at closely; examining; mumbled — talk indistinctly; usually in a low voice; cambric — a fine, thin cotton or linen cloth. “inspecting”: Origin of “inspect”: Latin inspectum.
Words: sedulous: careful and persistent · scuttled: ran with short quick steps · inspecting: looking at closely; examining · mumbled: talk indistinctly; usually in a low voice · cambric: a fine, thin cotton or linen cloth

18–28 min · Background and context · I do (10 min)
Mini-lecture (read or adapt the script).
Published in Harper's Bazar in 1890. Freeman wrote about rural New England, where farm wives had little legal say over property. A regionalist story about a woman's independence; often paired with A Jury of Her Peers and The Story of an Hour. Characterization: Sarah is patient and firm; Adoniram is silent. Dialect: New England speech. Allusion: Sarah's move compared to historical "revolts." Watch for the barn: Adoniram's priorities; it becomes a home.

28–40 min · I do: modeled close reading · I do (12 min)
Model the close reading of the anchor quotation using the written think-aloud below.
First, meaning. I read "What are they digging for, mother" slowly and put it in my own words: Sarah asks her husband what the workers are digging, and he will not answer her. Next, craft. I notice it is a simple question, and the refusal to answer it says more than a long speech. The strongest word is "digging": it is the start of the new barn, the thing that will spark her revolt. Then, effect. Why does Sarah ask what the men are digging for? My answer: Sarah asks what the men are digging for because her husband makes major decisions without telling her; her question shows how little voice she has, which drives her to act.

> *What are they digging for, mother* *(The Revolt of "Mother", paragraph 23)*

Think-aloud: First, meaning. I read "What are they digging for, mother" slowly and put it in my own words: Sarah asks her husband what the workers are digging, and he will not answer her. Next, craft. I notice it is a simple question, and the refusal to answer it says more than a long speech. The strongest word is "digging": it is the start of the new barn, the thing that will spark her revolt. Then, effect. Why does Sarah ask what the men are digging for? My answer: Sarah asks what the men are digging for because her husband makes major decisions without telling her; her question shows how little voice she has, which drives her to act.

40–55 min · We do: guided annotation · We do (15 min)
Guided analysis of a second quotation; expected answers given.
Ask: What words in this line stand out, and what do they suggest? Expected: The end. Look at the craft: New England speech. Ask: How does this line connect to quiet rebellion? Expected: She acts rather than argues. (The end.)

> *Sarah put her apron up to her face; she was overcome by her own triumph* *(The Revolt of "Mother", paragraph 165)*

Ask: What words in this line stand out, and what do they suggest?
Expected answer: The end. Look at the craft: New England speech.
Ask: How does this line connect to quiet rebellion?
Expected answer: She acts rather than argues. (The end.)

55–70 min · You do: independent annotation · You do (15 min)

Independent annotation and a claim-evidence-reasoning paragraph (exemplar given).

Annotate the story for characterization, dialect (three marks with a margin note each), then write one claim-evidence-reasoning paragraph: what does this story suggest about a wife's quiet rebellion for a decent home? Then start your writing prompt at your assigned level (HS Sophomore: Analyze how The Revolt of "Mother" develops the idea of a wife's quiet rebellion for a decent home. Make a precise claim, support it with at least three pieces of textual evidence, and explain how the author's use of characterization and conflict shapes that idea. Address one possible counterclaim.) Exemplar: Sarah's action succeeds where forty years of words failed. When the text says “Sarah put her apron up to her face; she was overcome by her own triumph” (The Revolt of "Mother", paragraph 165), it shows this directly. Adoniram admits "I hadn't no idee you was so set on't," and "Sarah put her apron up to her face; she was overcome by her own triumph."

Task: Annotate the story for characterization, dialect (three marks with a margin note each), then write one claim-evidence-reasoning paragraph: what does this story suggest about a wife's quiet rebellion for a decent home? Then start your writing prompt at your assigned level (HS Sophomore: Analyze how The Revolt of "Mother" develops the idea of a wife's quiet rebellion for a decent home. Make a precise claim, support it with at least three pieces of textual evidence, and explain how the author's use of characterization and conflict shapes that idea. Address one possible counterclaim.)

Exemplar: Sarah's action succeeds where forty years of words failed. When the text says “Sarah put her apron up to her face; she was overcome by her own triumph” (The Revolt of "Mother", paragraph 165), it shows this directly. Adoniram admits "I hadn't no idee you was so set on't," and "Sarah put her apron up to her face; she was overcome by her own triumph."

70–80 min · Discussion · We do (10 min)

Structured discussion from the 30 tiered questions, with facilitation notes.

Anchor question: How can someone stand up for themselves without shouting? Ask: is Sarah's revolt justified?

Anchor question: How can someone stand up for themselves without shouting?

Facilitation: Ask: is Sarah's revolt justified?

80–87 min · Exit ticket / chapter quiz · You do (7 min)

Story quiz in the app and an exit ticket (answer given).

Story quiz in the app, then: In one sentence, what does this story suggest about a wife's quiet rebellion for a decent home? Support it with one short quotation. Model answer: Sarah's action succeeds where forty years of words failed. (“Sarah put her apron up to her face; she was overcome by her own triumph”, The Revolt of "Mother", paragraph 165). Accept any defensible claim backed by a quotation from the story; the answer key for the quiz is in the Quiz section.

Exit ticket: In one sentence, what does this story suggest about a wife's quiet rebellion for a decent home? Support it with one short quotation.

Answer: Model answer: Sarah's action succeeds where forty years of words failed. (“Sarah put her apron up to her face; she was overcome by her own triumph”, The Revolt of "Mother", paragraph 165). Accept any defensible claim backed by a quotation from the story; the answer key for the quiz is in the Quiz section.

> **87–90 min · Closure · I do (3 min)**
> Summarize the lesson and preview the next reading.
> *Today we saw how characterization shapes a wife's quiet rebellion for a decent home. Key takeaway: she acts rather than argues.*

Total: 90 minutes.

Teacher analysis (spoilers)

Literary elements

- **Characterization:** Sarah is patient and firm; Adoniram is silent.
- **Dialect:** New England speech.
- **Allusion:** Sarah's move compared to historical "revolts."

Themes and how they develop

- **quiet rebellion:** she acts rather than argues.

Symbols and motifs

- **the barn:** Adoniram's priorities; it becomes a home.

Key quotations (checked against the reading text)

- “What are they digging for, mother” (The Revolt of "Mother", paragraph 23) The question.
- “Sarah put her apron up to her face; she was overcome by her own triumph” (The Revolt of "Mother", paragraph 165) The end.
- “I hadn't no idee you was so set on't” (The Revolt of "Mother", paragraph 166) Adoniram.

Model claim-evidence-reasoning

Claim: Sarah's action succeeds where forty years of words failed.
Evidence: “Sarah put her apron up to her face; she was overcome by her own triumph” (The Revolt of "Mother", paragraph 165)
Reasoning: Adoniram admits "I hadn't no idee you was so set on't," and "Sarah put her apron up to her face; she was overcome by her own triumph."

Vocabulary with etymology notes

Word	Definition (in this sentence)	In context	Word history
sedulous (adjective)	careful and persistent	*However deep a resentment she might be forced to hold against her husband, she would never fail in sedulous attention to his wants.*	

scuttled (verb)	ran with short quick steps	*Men assembled in the store and talked it over, women with shawls over their heads scuttled into each other's houses before their work was done.*	
inspecting (verb)	looking at closely; examining	*Penn did not speak of it, and Adoniram did not mention it to her, although sometimes, upon a return from inspecting it, he bore himself with injured dignity.*	"inspecting": Origin of "inspect": Latin inspectum. (Liber et Libri origin note, https://en.wiktionary.org/wiki/inspect#Etymology)
mumbled (verb)	talk indistinctly; usually in a low voice	*And the old man bent his head and mumbled.*	
cambric (noun)	a fine, thin cotton or linen cloth	*Nanny was to be married in the fall, and she was sewing on some white cambric and embroidery.*	
premises (noun)	a house or building together with its grounds	*The hired man had milked, but he still hung around the premises.*	
retreated (verb)	pull back or move away or backward	*He added some more perplexed apologetic remarks; then he retreated.*	
solemnity (noun)	a trait of dignified seriousness	*When he had cleared the door-step, he turned and looked back with a kind of nervous solemnity. "I shall be back by Saturday if nothin' happens," said he.*	"solemnity": Origin: Old French solemnite; earlier Latin sollemnitās. (Liber et Libri origin note, https://en.wiktionary.org/wiki/solemnity#Etymology)
assembled (verb)	create by putting components or members together	*Men assembled in the store and talked it over, women with shawls over their heads scuttled into each other's houses before their work was done.*	

Discussion questions

1. How can someone stand up for themselves without shouting?
2. Where does characterization appear in this story, and what effect does it have? Point to one passage.
3. How does this story connect to the book's larger concern with women's rights in marriage?

Classroom discussion questions (30, tiered)

Wait time after every question (3 s for DOK 1, 5 s for DOK 2, 8 to 10 s for DOK 3 and 4); think-pair-share on DOK 3 and 4; answer each response with a follow-up probe; close with student-generated questions. Focus sets by rigor level: Scaffolded support: 1, 2, 3, 4, 5, 6, 11, 12, 13, 14, 21, 22; HS Freshman: 1, 2, 3, 4, 5, 12, 13, 14, 15, 22, 23, 24; HS Sophomore: 1, 2, 3, 4, 13, 14, 15, 16, 17, 23, 24, 25; HS Junior: 1, 2, 3, 14, 15, 16, 17, 18, 24, 25, 26, 27; HS Senior: 1, 2, 3, 15, 16, 17, 18, 25, 26, 27, 28, 29; AP: 1, 2, 16,

17, 18, 19, 20, 26, 27, 28, 29, 30; College Freshman: 1, 2, 17, 18, 19, 20, 21, 22, 27, 28, 29, 30; College Sophomore: 1, 2, 11, 18, 19, 20, 21, 22, 23, 28, 29, 30; College Junior: 1, 11, 12, 19, 20, 21, 22, 23, 24, 25, 29, 30; College Senior: 1, 11, 12, 13, 20, 21, 22, 23, 24, 25, 26, 30; Graduate / PhD: 1, 11, 12, 13, 21, 22, 23, 24, 25, 26, 27, 28

Literal / recall

1. What has Adoniram promised Sarah? [DOK 1 · coldCallWithSupport · wait 3 s · RL.9-10.1, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.1] Look for: A new house
2. What is Adoniram building? [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.9-10.1, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.1] Look for: A new barn
3. When does Sarah act? [DOK 1 · coldCallWithSupport · wait 3 s · RL.9-10.1, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.1] Look for: While Adoniram is away buying a horse
4. What does Sarah do? [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.9-10.1, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.1] Look for: Moves the family into the new barn
5. How does Adoniram react? [DOK 1 · coldCallWithSupport · wait 3 s · RL.9-10.1, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.1] Look for: He weeps and agrees to finish it as a house
6. Retell the three most important events of “The Revolt of "Mother"” in order, in one sentence each. [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.9-10.1, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.1] Look for: For forty years Sarah Penn has waited for the new house her husband Adoniram promised. Instead he builds another barn. While he is away buying a horse, she moves the family and furniture into the new barn and makes it a home. Adoniram returns, is stunned, and weeps, saying he will put up partitions and windows: he never knew she was so set on it.
7. Which characters appear or are mentioned in “The Revolt of "Mother"”? Name two and one thing each says or does. [DOK 1 · coldCallWithSupport · wait 3 s · RL.9-10.1, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.1] Look for: Names and actions taken from the story; check against the teacher summary.
8. Where and when does “The Revolt of "Mother"” take place? Point to the line that tells you. [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.9-10.1, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.1] Look for: A place/time detail quoted from the story.
9. Reread: “However deep a resentment she might be forced to hold against her husband, she would never fail in sedulous attention to his wants.” What does “sedulous” mean here, and what is literally happening in this line? [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.9-10.1, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.1] Look for: sedulous: careful and persistent.
10. Reread: “Men assembled in the store and talked it over, women with shawls over their heads scuttled into each other's houses before their work was done.” What does “scuttled” mean here, and what is literally happening in this line? [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.9-10.1, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.1] Look for: scuttled: ran with short quick steps.

Inferential / analytical

1. What does “The Revolt of "Mother"” suggest about a wife's quiet rebellion for a decent home? State the inference and the line that supports it. [DOK 2 · thinkPairShare · wait 5 s · RL.9-10.2, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.2] Look for: A regionalist story about a woman's independence; often paired with A Jury of Her Peers and The Story of an Hour.
2. Find one example of characterization in this story. What does it reveal that a plain statement would not? [DOK 2 · followUp · wait 5 s · RL.9-10.3, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.3] Look for: Look for what characters say, do and think, and how others react to them.
3. How does the conflict in this story shape what we understand about a wife's quiet rebellion for a decent home? [DOK 3 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.3, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.3] Look for: Look for the forces, people or desires pulling against each other.

Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Sarah's action succeeds where forty years of words failed. Useful evidence: “What are they digging for, mother” (The Revolt of "Mother", paragraph 23): The question. Theme link: she acts rather than argues. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

4. In the passage that begins “Sarah Penn's face as she rolled her pies had that expression of meek vigor which might have characterized one of the New Testament saints.”, why might Freeman have chosen these particular words? Pick two and explain their connotations. [DOK 2 · followUp · wait 5 s · RL.9-10.4, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.4] Look for: Diction analysis of two words in the anchor passage.
5. What causes the main turn in “The Revolt of "Mother"”, and what effect is it likely to have on what follows? [DOK 2 · followUp · wait 5 s · RL.9-10.3, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.3] Look for: For forty years Sarah Penn has waited for the new house her husband Adoniram promised. Instead he builds another barn. While he is away buying a horse, she moves the family and furniture into the new barn and makes it a home. Adoniram returns, is stunned, and weeps, saying he will put up partitions…
6. As the opening story, what does “The Revolt of "Mother"” set up that the rest of The Revolt of "Mother" will need? [DOK 3 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.5, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.5] Look for: A causal or structural link between this and the previous story.

   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Sarah's action succeeds where forty years of words failed. Useful evidence: “Sarah put her apron up to her face; she was overcome by her own triumph” (The Revolt of "Mother", paragraph 165): The end. Theme link: she acts rather than argues. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
7. What can we infer about a character's motives from what they say and do here, as opposed to what they claim? [DOK 3 · followUp · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.3, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.3] Look for: An inference about motive supported by a quoted line.

   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Sarah's action succeeds where forty years of words failed. Useful evidence: “I hadn't no idee you was so set on't” (The Revolt of "Mother", paragraph 166): Adoniram. On characterization: Sarah is patient and firm; Adoniram is silent. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
8. The bell-ringer asked: “How can someone stand up for themselves without shouting?” Now that we have read closely, how would you revise your first answer, and which line changed your mind? [DOK 2 · thinkPairShare · wait 5 s · RL.9-10.2, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.2] Look for: A revised answer anchored in the text.
9. Where does diction / vocabulary appear, and how does it connect this story to the larger concern with women's rights in marriage? [DOK 3 · followUp · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.4, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.4] Look for: Look for precise or unusual word choices and their connotations.

   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Sarah's action succeeds where forty years of words failed. Useful evidence: “What are they digging for, mother” (The Revolt of "Mother", paragraph 23): The question. Theme link: she acts rather than argues. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
10. Background: Published in Harper's Bazar in 1890. Freeman wrote about rural New England, where farm wives had little legal say over property. How does knowing this change the way you read one moment in the story? [DOK 3 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.3, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.3] Look for: A specific moment reread in light of the context.

    Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Sarah's action succeeds where forty years of words

failed. Useful evidence: “Sarah put her apron up to her face; she was overcome by her own triumph” (The Revolt of "Mother", paragraph 165): The end. Theme link: she acts rather than argues. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

Evaluative / synthesis / creative

1. A critic might argue: “A regionalist story about a woman's independence; often paired with A Jury of Her Peers and The Story of an Hour.” How far do you agree? Take a stand and defend it with two lines from the story. [DOK 3 · fourCorners · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.2, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.2] Look for: A defended position with evidence and one counterpoint.
   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Sarah's action succeeds where forty years of words failed. Useful evidence: “I hadn't no idee you was so set on't” (The Revolt of "Mother", paragraph 166): Adoniram. Theme link: she acts rather than argues. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
2. Which character in this story acts most wisely, and which least? Judge them by a standard you name. [DOK 3 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.3, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.3] Look for: An evaluation using an explicit criterion and evidence.
   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Sarah's action succeeds where forty years of words failed. Useful evidence: “What are they digging for, mother” (The Revolt of "Mother", paragraph 23): The question. On characterization: Sarah is patient and firm; Adoniram is silent. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
3. Rewrite one moment of “The Revolt of "Mother"” from the point of view of a different character. What does the new angle reveal or hide about a wife's quiet rebellion for a decent home? [DOK 4 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.1, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.6] Look for: A creative product with a rationale tied to the text.
   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Sarah's action succeeds where forty years of words failed. Useful evidence: “Sarah put her apron up to her face; she was overcome by her own triumph” (The Revolt of "Mother", paragraph 165): The end. Theme link: she acts rather than argues. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
4. Write three questions of your own about “The Revolt of "Mother"”: one recall, one “why/how”, and one “should/what if”. Trade with a partner and answer theirs. [DOK 3 · studentGenerated · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.2, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.2] Look for: Student-generated questions at three levels.
   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Sarah's action succeeds where forty years of words failed. Useful evidence: “I hadn't no idee you was so set on't” (The Revolt of "Mother", paragraph 166): Adoniram. Theme link: she acts rather than argues. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
5. Connect this story to home and dignity: is the link strong or weak so far? What would Freeman need to show next to strengthen it? [DOK 4 · socraticCircle · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.2, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.2] Look for: A judgment of thematic development across the work.
   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Sarah's action succeeds where forty years of words failed. Useful evidence: “What are they digging for, mother” (The Revolt of "Mother", paragraph 23): The question. Theme link: she acts rather than argues. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

6. Is the characterization in this story effective, or does it feel heavy-handed? Evaluate it as a reader would in a review. [DOK 3 · fourCorners · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.3, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.3] Look for: An evaluative judgment with criteria and evidence.
   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Sarah's action succeeds where forty years of words failed. Useful evidence: “Sarah put her apron up to her face; she was overcome by her own triumph” (The Revolt of "Mother", paragraph 165): The end. On characterization: Sarah is patient and firm; Adoniram is silent. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
7. Compare how “The Revolt of "Mother"” treats a wife's quiet rebellion for a decent home with how another text, film or event you know treats a similar idea. What does The Revolt of "Mother" see that the other misses? [DOK 4 · socraticCircle · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.2, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.2] Look for: A cross-text synthesis.
   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Sarah's action succeeds where forty years of words failed. Useful evidence: “I hadn't no idee you was so set on't” (The Revolt of "Mother", paragraph 166): Adoniram. Theme link: she acts rather than argues. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
8. As the final story, does this ending resolve women's rights in marriage? Argue whether the ending is earned. [DOK 3 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.5, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.5] Look for: A prediction or judgment justified with textual clues.
   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Sarah's action succeeds where forty years of words failed. Useful evidence: “What are they digging for, mother” (The Revolt of "Mother", paragraph 23): The question. Theme link: she acts rather than argues. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
9. Design a one-paragraph modern adaptation of this story (setting, characters, conflict). What must stay the same for it to still be about a wife's quiet rebellion for a decent home? [DOK 4 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.2, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.2] Look for: A creative transfer that keeps the core idea.
   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Sarah's action succeeds where forty years of words failed. Useful evidence: “Sarah put her apron up to her face; she was overcome by her own triumph” (The Revolt of "Mother", paragraph 165): The end. Theme link: she acts rather than argues. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
10. What question would you most like to ask Mary E. Wilkins Freeman about this story, and what answer do you think the text itself gives? [DOK 4 · studentGenerated · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.2, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.2] Look for: A student-generated question answered from evidence.
    Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Sarah's action succeeds where forty years of words failed. Useful evidence: “I hadn't no idee you was so set on't” (The Revolt of "Mother", paragraph 166): Adoniram. Theme link: she acts rather than argues. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

Annotation focus

- **Characterization:** look for what characters say, do and think, and how others react to them (anchor passage in the We do segment)
- Also notice **Conflict**: the forces, people or desires pulling against each other
- Also notice **Diction / vocabulary**: precise or unusual word choices and their connotations

Chapter quiz: item bank (all eleven rigor versions)

1. [mc · recall · DOK 1] When does Sarah act?
   A. After he dies
   B. While Adoniram is away buying a horse
   C. On Sunday
   D. At night
   Key: B (While Adoniram is away buying a horse)
2. [mc · recall · DOK 1] What has Adoniram promised Sarah?
   A. A new dress
   B. A horse
   C. A new house
   D. A trip to Boston
   Key: C (A new house)
3. [mc · recall · DOK 1] What does Sarah do?
   A. Leaves her husband
   B. Moves the family into the new barn
   C. Sells the farm
   D. Burns the barn
   Key: B (Moves the family into the new barn)
4. [fill · recall · DOK 1] Fill in the blank with the vocabulary word that fits: “He added some more perplexed apologetic remarks; then he _____.” Word bank: retreated, inspecting, sedulous, scuttled
   Key: retreated
5. [fill · recall · DOK 1] Fill in the blank with the vocabulary word that fits: “When he had cleared the door-step, he turned and looked back with a kind of nervous _____. "I shall be back by Saturday if nothin' happens," said he.” Word bank: solemnity, inspecting, sedulous, scuttled
   Key: solemnity
6. [fill · recall · DOK 1] Fill in the blank with the vocabulary word that fits: “The hired man had milked, but he still hung around the _____.” Word bank: inspecting, premises, scuttled, sedulous
   Key: premises
7. [fill · recall · DOK 1] Complete the quotation from The Revolt of "Mother", paragraph 165: “Sarah put her apron up to her face; she was _____ by her own triumph”
   Key: overcome
8. [fill · recall · DOK 1] Fill in the blank with the vocabulary word that fits: “Nanny was to be married in the fall, and she was sewing on some white _____ and embroidery.” Word bank: scuttled, sedulous, cambric, inspecting
   Key: cambric
9. [mc · recall · DOK 1] How does Adoniram react?
   A. He is furious
   B. He moves out
   C. He sells the barn
   D. He weeps and agrees to finish it as a house

Key: D (He weeps and agrees to finish it as a house)

10. [fill · recall · DOK 1] Complete the quotation from The Revolt of "Mother", paragraph 23: “What are they _____ for, mother”

    Key: digging

11. [short · inference · DOK 2] What can you infer from this line? “What are they digging for, mother” (The Revolt of "Mother", paragraph 23) Answer in two or three sentences with one detail.

    Sample answer: The question.

12. [short · inference · DOK 2] What can you infer from this line? “Sarah put her apron up to her face; she was overcome by her own triumph” (The Revolt of "Mother", paragraph 165) Answer in two or three sentences with one detail.

    Sample answer: The end.

13. [mc · inference · DOK 2] Which choice best states a central concern of “The Revolt of "Mother"”?

    A. A boy's romantic quest ending in disillusion

    B. The cost of wanting to seem richer than you are

    C. Love measured by sacrifice

    D. A wife's quiet rebellion for a decent home

    Key: D (A wife's quiet rebellion for a decent home)

14. [mc · analysis · DOK 3] Which literary element does this describe in “The Revolt of "Mother"”? Sarah is patient and firm; Adoniram is silent.

    A. Characterization

    B. Imagery

    C. Metaphor

    D. Simile

    Key: A (Characterization)

15. [mc · analysis · DOK 3] Which literary element does this describe in “The Revolt of "Mother"”? New England speech.

    A. Foreshadowing

    B. Theme

    C. Simile

    D. Dialect

    Key: D (Dialect)

16. [short · synthesis · DOK 4] Close reading: how do the diction and syntax of “What are they digging for, mother” (The Revolt of "Mother", paragraph 23) shape its meaning? Consider a second, competing reading.

    Sample answer: The question.

17. [mc · recall · DOK 1] What is Adoniram building?

    A. A church

    B. A store

    C. A school

    D. A new barn

Key: D (A new barn)

18. [short · analysis · DOK 3] Claim: Sarah's action succeeds where forty years of words failed. Explain how this evidence supports the claim: “Sarah put her apron up to her face; she was overcome by her own triumph” (The Revolt of "Mother", paragraph 165).
    Sample answer: Adoniram admits "I hadn't no idee you was so set on't," and "Sarah put her apron up to her face; she was overcome by her own triumph."
19. [short · analysis · DOK 3] Analyze the word choice in “I hadn't no idee you was so set on't” (The Revolt of "Mother", paragraph 166). Pick two words and explain what they suggest.
    Sample answer: Adoniram.
20. [short · synthesis · DOK 4] Synthesis: trace how quiet rebellion develops from an earlier story to “The Revolt of "Mother"”. Use one quotation from each.
    Sample answer: she acts rather than argues.
21. [short · synthesis · DOK 4] Evaluate this claim about the story: “Sarah's action succeeds where forty years of words failed.” Is it fully persuasive? Argue with evidence, including a passage that complicates it.
    Sample answer: Adoniram admits "I hadn't no idee you was so set on't," and "Sarah put her apron up to her face; she was overcome by her own triumph."
22. [mc · recall · DOK 1] In the line “And the old man bent his head and mumbled.”, what does “mumbled” most nearly mean?
    A. talk indistinctly; usually in a low voice
    B. ran with short quick steps
    C. careful and persistent
    D. looking at closely; examining

    Key: A (talk indistinctly; usually in a low voice)
23. [short · synthesis · DOK 4] Close reading: how do the diction and syntax of “Sarah put her apron up to her face; she was overcome by her own triumph” (The Revolt of "Mother", paragraph 165) shape its meaning? Consider a second, competing reading.
    Sample answer: The end.
24. [mc · recall · DOK 1] In the line “However deep a resentment she might be forced to hold against her husband, she would never fail in sedulous attention to his wants.”, what does “sedulous” most nearly mean?
    A. ran with short quick steps
    B. careful and persistent
    C. looking at closely; examining
    D. talk indistinctly; usually in a low voice

    Key: B (careful and persistent)
25. [mc · recall · DOK 1] In the line “Men assembled in the store and talked it over, women with shawls over their heads scuttled into each other's houses before their work was done.”, what does “scuttled” most nearly mean?
    A. careful and persistent
    B. looking at closely; examining
    C. ran with short quick steps
    D. talk indistinctly; usually in a low voice

Key: C (ran with short quick steps)

Rigor version	Items (in order)	Mix
Scaffolded support	1, 2, 3, 4, 5, 6, 7, 8, 9, 10, 11, 12, 13, 14, 15, 16	recall 10, inference 3, analysis 2, synthesis 1
HS Freshman	5, 8, 10, 2, 7, 3, 17, 1, 6, 13, 11, 12, 15, 18, 14, 16	recall 9, inference 3, analysis 3, synthesis 1
HS Sophomore	17, 6, 8, 4, 9, 5, 10, 1, 12, 11, 13, 15, 14, 19, 20, 16	recall 8, inference 3, analysis 3, synthesis 2
HS Junior	9, 4, 2, 7, 17, 8, 3, 12, 11, 13, 18, 15, 19, 14, 21, 16	recall 7, inference 3, analysis 4, synthesis 2
HS Senior	4, 1, 3, 7, 8, 10, 13, 12, 11, 14, 18, 15, 19, 21, 20, 16	recall 6, inference 3, analysis 4, synthesis 3
AP	8, 5, 2, 3, 22, 11, 13, 12, 18, 15, 14, 19, 23, 21, 16, 20	recall 5, inference 3, analysis 4, synthesis 4
College Freshman	10, 24, 17, 3, 6, 13, 12, 11, 19, 18, 15, 14, 16, 20, 21, 23	recall 5, inference 3, analysis 4, synthesis 4
College Sophomore	25, 17, 8, 22, 4, 11, 13, 12, 19, 14, 15, 18, 23, 21, 16, 20	recall 5, inference 3, analysis 4, synthesis 4
College Junior	8, 10, 1, 2, 9, 13, 11, 12, 15, 18, 19, 14, 20, 16, 21, 23	recall 5, inference 3, analysis 4, synthesis 4
College Senior	8, 4, 3, 17, 22, 11, 12, 13, 19, 18, 14, 15, 20, 23, 21, 16	recall 5, inference 3, analysis 4, synthesis 4
Graduate / PhD	6, 4, 17, 24, 2, 13, 12, 11, 14, 15, 19, 18, 16, 20, 21, 23	recall 5, inference 3, analysis 4, synthesis 4

Writing prompts (eleven rigor levels)

Scaffolded support (250 words; Common Core: RL.9-10.3, W.9-10.1): Supported track (work from the passage your teacher selects). In “The Revolt of "Mother"," how does Freeman show a wife's quiet rebellion for a decent home? Write a paragraph that states your claim, quotes two details from the passage, and explains how each detail supports your idea. Use the characterization you noticed as one piece of evidence.

HS Freshman (350 words; Common Core: RL.9-10.3, W.9-10.1): In The Revolt of "Mother", how does Freeman develop the idea of a wife's quiet rebellion for a decent home? State a clear claim, support it with two or three quotations, and explain how the characterization in the story helps build that idea.

HS Sophomore (450 words; Common Core: RL.9-10.3, W.9-10.1): Analyze how The Revolt of "Mother" develops the idea of a wife's quiet rebellion for a decent home. Make a precise claim, support it with at least three pieces of textual evidence, and explain how the author's use of characterization and conflict shapes that idea. Address one possible counterclaim.

HS Junior (550 words; Common Core: RL.11-12.5, RL.11-12.1, W.11-12.1, RL.11-12.9): Analyze how the structure of The Revolt of "Mother" (where it begins, turns and ends) and its characterization shape the reader's understanding of a wife's quiet rebellion for a decent home. Identify one place where the text leaves matters uncertain and explain how that uncertainty adds to its meaning.

HS Senior (600 words; Common Core: RL.11-12.3, W.11-12.1, RL.11-12.9): Two readers disagree about what The Revolt of "Mother" suggests about a wife's quiet rebellion for a decent home. Lay out two plausible interpretations, weigh the evidence for each (including the story's characterization and conflict), and argue for the stronger one in a sustained, well-organized essay.

AP (650 words; Common Core: RL.11-12.3, W.11-12.1): Write a literary argument in which you analyze how Mary E. Wilkins Freeman uses characterization in The Revolt of "Mother" to complicate the reader's understanding of a wife's quiet rebellion for a decent home. Develop a defensible thesis, select evidence purposefully, and explain how specific choices of diction and syntax create meaning.

College Freshman (1000 words; Common Core: ICC-WC-1.3, ICC-WC-1.5, ICC-WC-1.1): Situate The Revolt of "Mother" within its historical and literary context and argue how the story's treatment of a wife's quiet rebellion for a decent home responds to that context. Engage with at least one secondary perspective (a critic, historian or the author's own statements), integrate quotations smoothly, and cite in MLA style.

College Sophomore (1250 words; Common Core: LeL-C2-LIT-1, LeL-C2-W-1): Read The Revolt of "Mother" alongside the conventions of its genre and period. Argue how the story's handling of a wife's quiet rebellion for a decent home follows or bends those conventions, using the characterization as evidence, and test your reading against one published critic. Document two secondary sources in MLA.

College Junior (1500 words; Common Core: LeL-C3-LIT-1, LeL-C3-W-1): Apply a named critical approach (for example formalist, historicist, feminist, psychoanalytic or ecocritical) to The Revolt of "Mother" and its treatment of a wife's quiet rebellion for a decent home. State your method, show what it reveals in the story's characterization and conflict, and identify where the text resists it.

College Senior (2000 words; Common Core: LeL-C4-LIT-1, LeL-C4-W-1): Develop a research argument that reads The Revolt of "Mother" as evidence for a larger claim about a wife's quiet rebellion for a decent home in The Revolt of "Mother". Connect close reading of the story to the whole story, engage at least four scholarly sources, and state precisely where your reading departs from theirs (Chicago style).

Graduate / PhD (2500 words; Common Core: LeL-GR-LIT-1, LeL-GR-W-1): Develop an original argument that reads The Revolt of "Mother" as a hinge in the story's larger treatment of a wife's quiet rebellion for a decent home. Position your reading within a named critical conversation (for example formalist, historicist, psychoanalytic, feminist or postcolonial approaches), account for the textual history where relevant, and articulate the stakes of your intervention for scholarship on The Revolt of "Mother".

SAT-style questions

1. *Penn did not speak of it, and Adoniram did not mention it to her, although sometimes, upon a return from inspecting it, he bore himself with injured dignity.*

   As used in the text, what does the word “inspecting” most nearly mean?

   A. create by putting components or members together

   B. looking at closely; examining

   C. a trait of dignified seriousness

   D. pull back or move away or backward

2. *Sarah Penn's face as she rolled her pies had that expression of meek vigor which might have characterized one of the New Testament saints. She was making mince-pies. Her husband, Adoniram Penn, liked them better than any other kind. She baked twice a week. Adoniram often liked a piece of pie between meals. She hurried this morning. It had been later than usual when she began, and she wanted to have a pie baked for dinner.*

> *However deep a resentment she might be forced to hold against her husband, she would never fail in sedulous attention to his wants.*

Which choice best states a central concern of “The Revolt of "Mother"”?

A. A wife's quiet rebellion for a decent home

B. A woman's brief taste of freedom

C. A girl's first encounter with death across the class line

D. Hope created by an act of sacrifice

SAT key: 1. B (looking at closely; examining); 2. A (A wife's quiet rebellion for a decent home)

Unit test

The Revolt of "Mother": end test · 90 minutes · 18 questions per rigor version (multiple choice, fill in the blank, short answer). The class rigor level picks the version; student auto-adjust applies.

Short-answer scoring guides

Scaffolded support and HS Freshman (2 points): correct answer in a complete sentence with a detail from the text. HS Sophomore to HS Senior (3 points): claim, one accurate quotation, one sentence of explanation. AP to College Sophomore (4 points): precise claim, two embedded quotations, commentary on word choice or structure, link to theme. College Junior to Graduate (5 points): nuanced thesis, close reading of two passages, synthesis across sections, a competing reading answered. Each item lists a sample answer; partial credit is described in the app.

Unit test: item bank (all eleven rigor versions)

1. [mc · recall · DOK 1] What does Sarah do?
   A. Leaves her husband
   B. Moves the family into the new barn
   C. Sells the farm
   D. Burns the barn

   Key: B (Moves the family into the new barn)
2. [fill · recall · DOK 1] Fill in the blank with the vocabulary word that fits: “When he had cleared the door-step, he turned and looked back with a kind of nervous _____. "I shall be back by Saturday if nothin' happens," said he.” Word bank: solemnity, inspecting, sedulous, scuttled

   Key: solemnity
3. [fill · recall · DOK 1] Fill in the blank with the vocabulary word that fits: “Nanny was to be married in the fall, and she was sewing on some white _____ and embroidery.” Word bank: scuttled, sedulous, cambric, inspecting

   Key: cambric
4. [fill · recall · DOK 1] Complete the quotation from The Revolt of "Mother", paragraph 23: “What are they _____ for, mother”

   Key: digging
5. [fill · recall · DOK 1] Fill in the blank with the vocabulary word that fits: “He added some more perplexed apologetic remarks; then he _____.” Word bank: retreated, inspecting, sedulous, scuttled

   Key: retreated
6. [fill · recall · DOK 1] Fill in the blank with the vocabulary word that fits: “The hired man had milked, but he still hung around the _____.” Word bank: inspecting, premises, scuttled, sedulous

   Key: premises
7. [mc · recall · DOK 1] What has Adoniram promised Sarah?
   A. A new dress
   B. A horse
   C. A new house
   D. A trip to Boston

Key: C (A new house)

8. [fill · recall · DOK 1] Complete the quotation from The Revolt of "Mother", paragraph 165: “Sarah put her apron up to her face; she was _____ by her own triumph”

   Key: overcome

9. [mc · recall · DOK 1] What is Adoniram building?

   A. A church

   B. A store

   C. A school

   D. A new barn

   Key: D (A new barn)

10. [mc · recall · DOK 1] How does Adoniram react?

    A. He is furious

    B. He moves out

    C. He sells the barn

    D. He weeps and agrees to finish it as a house

    Key: D (He weeps and agrees to finish it as a house)

11. [mc · recall · DOK 1] When does Sarah act?

    A. After he dies

    B. While Adoniram is away buying a horse

    C. On Sunday

    D. At night

    Key: B (While Adoniram is away buying a horse)

12. [mc · inference · DOK 2] Which choice best states a central concern of “The Revolt of "Mother"”?

    A. A boy's romantic quest ending in disillusion

    B. The cost of wanting to seem richer than you are

    C. Love measured by sacrifice

    D. A wife's quiet rebellion for a decent home

    Key: D (A wife's quiet rebellion for a decent home)

13. [short · inference · DOK 2] What can you infer from this line? “Sarah put her apron up to her face; she was overcome by her own triumph” (The Revolt of "Mother", paragraph 165) Answer in two or three sentences with one detail.

    Sample answer: The end.

14. [short · inference · DOK 2] What can you infer from this line? “What are they digging for, mother” (The Revolt of "Mother", paragraph 23) Answer in two or three sentences with one detail.

    Sample answer: The question.

15. [mc · analysis · DOK 3] Which literary element does this describe in “The Revolt of "Mother"”? Sarah is patient and firm; Adoniram is silent.

    A. Characterization

    B. Imagery

    C. Metaphor

D. Simile

Key: A (Characterization)

16. [short · analysis · DOK 3] Analyze the word choice in “I hadn't no idee you was so set on't” (The Revolt of "Mother", paragraph 166). Pick two words and explain what they suggest.
    Sample answer: Adoniram.

17. [short · analysis · DOK 3] Claim: Sarah's action succeeds where forty years of words failed. Explain how this evidence supports the claim: “Sarah put her apron up to her face; she was overcome by her own triumph” (The Revolt of "Mother", paragraph 165).
    Sample answer: Adoniram admits "I hadn't no idee you was so set on't," and "Sarah put her apron up to her face; she was overcome by her own triumph."

18. [short · synthesis · DOK 4] Evaluate this claim about the story: “Sarah's action succeeds where forty years of words failed.” Is it fully persuasive? Argue with evidence, including a passage that complicates it.
    Sample answer: Adoniram admits "I hadn't no idee you was so set on't," and "Sarah put her apron up to her face; she was overcome by her own triumph."

19. [mc · analysis · DOK 3] Which literary element does this describe in “The Revolt of "Mother"”? New England speech.

    A. Foreshadowing

    B. Theme

    C. Simile

    D. Dialect

    Key: D (Dialect)

20. [short · synthesis · DOK 4] Close reading: how do the diction and syntax of “What are they digging for, mother” (The Revolt of "Mother", paragraph 23) shape its meaning? Consider a second, competing reading.
    Sample answer: The question.

21. [short · synthesis · DOK 4] Close reading: how do the diction and syntax of “Sarah put her apron up to her face; she was overcome by her own triumph” (The Revolt of "Mother", paragraph 165) shape its meaning? Consider a second, competing reading.
    Sample answer: The end.

22. [short · synthesis · DOK 4] Synthesis: trace how quiet rebellion develops from an earlier story to “The Revolt of "Mother"”. Use one quotation from each.
    Sample answer: she acts rather than argues.

23. [mc · recall · DOK 1] In the line “However deep a resentment she might be forced to hold against her husband, she would never fail in sedulous attention to his wants.”, what does “sedulous” most nearly mean?

    A. ran with short quick steps

    B. careful and persistent

    C. looking at closely; examining

    D. talk indistinctly; usually in a low voice

    Key: B (careful and persistent)

24. [mc · recall · DOK 1] In the line “And the old man bent his head and mumbled.”, what does “mumbled” most nearly mean?

    A. talk indistinctly; usually in a low voice

    B. ran with short quick steps

    C. careful and persistent

    D. looking at closely; examining

    Key: A (talk indistinctly; usually in a low voice)

25. [mc · recall · DOK 1] In the line “Men assembled in the store and talked it over, women with shawls over their heads scuttled into each other's houses before their work was done.”, what does “scuttled” most nearly mean?

    A. careful and persistent

    B. looking at closely; examining

    C. ran with short quick steps

    D. talk indistinctly; usually in a low voice

    Key: C (ran with short quick steps)

26. [mc · recall · DOK 1] In the line “Penn did not speak of it, and Adoniram did not mention it to her, although sometimes, upon a return from inspecting it, he bore himself with injured dignity.”, what does “inspecting” most nearly mean?

    A. ran with short quick steps

    B. careful and persistent

    C. looking at closely; examining

    D. talk indistinctly; usually in a low voice

    Key: C (looking at closely; examining)

Rigor version	Items (in order)	Mix
Scaffolded support	1, 2, 3, 4, 5, 6, 7, 8, 9, 10, 11, 12, 13, 14, 15, 16, 17, 18	recall 11, inference 3, analysis 3, synthesis 1
HS Freshman	4, 2, 10, 7, 6, 3, 9, 1, 5, 11, 8, 13, 12, 14, 16, 19, 15, 18	recall 11, inference 3, analysis 3, synthesis 1
HS Sophomore	2, 7, 9, 6, 4, 1, 10, 11, 3, 8, 14, 12, 13, 17, 19, 15, 20, 21	recall 10, inference 3, analysis 3, synthesis 2
HS Junior	11, 6, 8, 2, 7, 5, 1, 4, 10, 13, 12, 14, 19, 16, 17, 15, 20, 22	recall 9, inference 3, analysis 4, synthesis 2
HS Senior	6, 3, 11, 4, 9, 1, 8, 2, 14, 13, 12, 15, 16, 17, 19, 18, 22, 21	recall 8, inference 3, analysis 4, synthesis 3
AP	1, 5, 10, 8, 9, 3, 4, 14, 13, 12, 16, 15, 17, 19, 18, 22, 21, 20	recall 7, inference 3, analysis 4, synthesis 4
College Freshman	6, 23, 10, 24, 9, 3, 11, 12, 14, 13, 16, 19, 17, 15, 18, 22, 20, 21	recall 7, inference 3, analysis 4, synthesis 4

College Sophomore	6, 25, 26, 1, 24, 4, 8, 14, 12, 13, 19, 17, 15, 16, 22, 21, 20, 18	recall 7, inference 3, analysis 4, synthesis 4
College Junior	4, 26, 24, 23, 8, 1, 3, 12, 13, 14, 17, 15, 19, 16, 22, 20, 21, 18	recall 7, inference 3, analysis 4, synthesis 4
College Senior	23, 9, 2, 4, 3, 10, 5, 12, 13, 14, 15, 16, 19, 17, 21, 22, 20, 18	recall 7, inference 3, analysis 4, synthesis 4
Graduate / PhD	4, 10, 5, 26, 8, 1, 25, 12, 13, 14, 16, 17, 19, 15, 21, 20, 22, 18	recall 7, inference 3, analysis 4, synthesis 4

Final paper

The Revolt of "Mother": final paper (formal literary analysis). Choose one prompt.

1. Analyze how Mary E. Wilkins Freeman develops women's rights in marriage across The Revolt of "Mother". Trace the idea through at least three moments (beginning, middle and end) and argue what the ending finally suggests.
2. Choose one recurring symbol, image or motif in The Revolt of "Mother" and argue how its meaning changes over the story and why that change matters to home and dignity.
3. Analyze a central character's choices in The Revolt of "Mother". Argue whether the story judges that character, and how its structure or point of view shapes your answer.
4. Two readers disagree about whether The Revolt of "Mother" finally endorses or criticizes its society's view of quiet rebellion. Weigh both readings and argue for one, answering the strongest objection.

Length: Scaffolded support 500-700 words; HS Freshman 700-900 words; HS Sophomore 900-1,100 words; HS Junior 1,000-1,300 words; HS Senior 1,200-1,500 words; AP 1,300-1,600 words; College Freshman 1,500-2,000 words; College Sophomore 2,000-2,500 words; College Junior 2,500-3,000 words; College Senior 3,000-4,000 words; Graduate / PhD 4,000-6,000 words

Evidence requirement: at least 4 quotations from at least two parts of the story. Quote the reading text exactly and cite the paragraph (MLA style). HS Senior and above: one scholarly or historical source; College Sophomore and above: two, cited in MLA.

Criterion	Points	Descriptor
Thesis	20	A specific, arguable claim that answers the prompt and organizes the paper.
Evidence	25	Well-chosen, accurately quoted and cited passages from across the work, meeting the evidence requirement.
Analysis	30	Explains how language, structure and literary elements create meaning; goes beyond summary.
Organization	15	Logical progression, clear topic sentences and transitions; introduction and conclusion frame the argument.
Style and conventions	10	Formal academic voice, present tense for literature, correct grammar and MLA format.

Essay assignments

Essay: Women's rights in marriage

Scaffolded support (600 words; Common Core: W.9-10.1, RL.9-10.2): Supported track: write a five-paragraph essay explaining what The Revolt of "Mother" teaches about women's rights in marriage. Use at least three quotations from passages your teacher selects from different parts of the book.

HS Freshman (800 words; Common Core: W.9-10.1, RL.9-10.2): Write a multi-paragraph essay explaining how Mary E. Wilkins Freeman develops women's rights in marriage in The Revolt of "Mother". Use evidence from the beginning, middle and end of the book.

HS Sophomore (1000 words; Common Core: W.9-10.1, RL.9-10.2): Write an argumentative essay analyzing how Mary E. Wilkins Freeman develops women's rights in marriage across The Revolt of "Mother". Trace the idea through at least three parts of the story and address a counterclaim.

HS Junior (1100 words; Common Core: W.11-12.1, RL.11-12.5): Write an analytical essay on how the structure of The Revolt of "Mother" (its order, turns and ending) shapes the meaning of women's rights in marriage. Discuss at least one place where the book leaves the question open.

HS Senior (1200 words; Common Core: W.11-12.1, RL.11-12.2): Write a sustained argument comparing two interpretations of women's rights in marriage in The Revolt of "Mother". Weigh the evidence for each and defend the stronger reading in a mature, well-organized essay.

AP (1300 words; Common Core: W.11-12.1, RL.11-12.2): Write a literary argument: develop a defensible thesis about how Mary E. Wilkins Freeman's choices in The Revolt of "Mother" (a recurring element, structure and narration) shape a complex understanding of women's rights in marriage, weigh at least one competing reading, and sustain commentary on well-chosen evidence. Do not merely summarize.

College Freshman (1600 words; Common Core: ICC-WC-1.5, ICC-WC-1.4, ICC-WC-1.7): Write a researched essay (4–6 pages) that places The Revolt of "Mother"'s treatment of women's rights in marriage in its historical context, using at least two scholarly sources.

College Sophomore (2200 words; Common Core: LeL-C2-W-1, LeL-C2-LIT-1): Write a contextual essay (6–8 pages) on women's rights in marriage in The Revolt of "Mother" that reads the story against its genre and period and engages two published critics. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

College Junior (2800 words; Common Core: LeL-C3-W-1, LeL-C3-LIT-1): Write a theoretically informed essay (8–10 pages) on women's rights in marriage in The Revolt of "Mother". Name your critical method, apply it closely, and acknowledge its limits. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

College Senior (4000 words; Common Core: LeL-C4-W-1, LeL-C4-LIT-1): Write a research paper (12–15 pages) with an original argument about women's rights in marriage in The Revolt of "Mother", engaging at

least four scholarly sources in Chicago style. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

Graduate / PhD (6000 words; Common Core: LeL-GR-W-1, LeL-GR-LIT-1): Write a seminar paper (15–20 pages) that intervenes in the critical conversation on women's rights in marriage in The Revolt of "Mother", engaging the relevant scholarship and textual history. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

Rubric: Claim · Evidence · Analysis · Organization · Conventions

Essay: Home and dignity

Scaffolded support (600 words; Common Core: W.9-10.1, RL.9-10.2): Supported track: write a five-paragraph essay explaining what The Revolt of "Mother" teaches about home and dignity. Use at least three quotations from passages your teacher selects from different parts of the book.

HS Freshman (800 words; Common Core: W.9-10.1, RL.9-10.2): Write a multi-paragraph essay explaining how Mary E. Wilkins Freeman develops home and dignity in The Revolt of "Mother". Use evidence from the beginning, middle and end of the book.

HS Sophomore (1000 words; Common Core: W.9-10.1, RL.9-10.2): Write an argumentative essay analyzing how Mary E. Wilkins Freeman develops home and dignity across The Revolt of "Mother". Trace the idea through at least three parts of the story and address a counterclaim.

HS Junior (1100 words; Common Core: W.11-12.1, RL.11-12.5): Write an analytical essay on how the structure of The Revolt of "Mother" (its order, turns and ending) shapes the meaning of home and dignity. Discuss at least one place where the book leaves the question open.

HS Senior (1200 words; Common Core: W.11-12.1, RL.11-12.2): Write a sustained argument comparing two interpretations of home and dignity in The Revolt of "Mother". Weigh the evidence for each and defend the stronger reading in a mature, well-organized essay.

AP (1300 words; Common Core: W.11-12.1, RL.11-12.2): Write a literary argument: develop a defensible thesis about how Mary E. Wilkins Freeman's choices in The Revolt of "Mother" (a recurring element, structure and narration) shape a complex understanding of home and dignity, weigh at least one competing reading, and sustain commentary on well-chosen evidence. Do not merely summarize.

College Freshman (1600 words; Common Core: ICC-WC-1.5, ICC-WC-1.4, ICC-WC-1.7): Write a researched essay (4–6 pages) that places The Revolt of "Mother"'s treatment of home and dignity in its historical context, using at least two scholarly sources.

College Sophomore (2200 words; Common Core: LeL-C2-W-1, LeL-C2-LIT-1): Write a contextual essay (6–8 pages) on home and dignity in The Revolt of "Mother" that reads the story against its genre and period and engages two published critics. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

College Junior (2800 words; Common Core: LeL-C3-W-1, LeL-C3-LIT-1): Write a theoretically informed essay (8–10 pages) on home and dignity in The Revolt of "Mother". Name your critical method, apply it closely, and acknowledge its limits. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

College Senior (4000 words; Common Core: LeL-C4-W-1, LeL-C4-LIT-1): Write a research paper (12–15 pages) with an original argument about home and dignity in The Revolt of "Mother", engaging at least four scholarly sources in Chicago style. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

Graduate / PhD (6000 words; Common Core: LeL-GR-W-1, LeL-GR-LIT-1): Write a seminar paper (15–20 pages) that intervenes in the critical conversation on home and dignity in The Revolt of "Mother", engaging the relevant scholarship and textual history. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

Rubric: Claim · Evidence · Analysis · Organization · Conventions

Essay: Quiet rebellion

Scaffolded support (600 words; Common Core: W.9-10.1, RL.9-10.2): Supported track: write a five-paragraph essay explaining what The Revolt of "Mother" teaches about quiet rebellion. Use at least three quotations from passages your teacher selects from different parts of the book.

HS Freshman (800 words; Common Core: W.9-10.1, RL.9-10.2): Write a multi-paragraph essay explaining how Mary E. Wilkins Freeman develops quiet rebellion in The Revolt of "Mother". Use evidence from the beginning, middle and end of the book.

HS Sophomore (1000 words; Common Core: W.9-10.1, RL.9-10.2): Write an argumentative essay analyzing how Mary E. Wilkins Freeman develops quiet rebellion across The Revolt of "Mother". Trace the idea through at least three parts of the story and address a counterclaim.

HS Junior (1100 words; Common Core: W.11-12.1, RL.11-12.5): Write an analytical essay on how the structure of The Revolt of "Mother" (its order, turns and ending) shapes the meaning of quiet rebellion. Discuss at least one place where the book leaves the question open.

HS Senior (1200 words; Common Core: W.11-12.1, RL.11-12.2): Write a sustained argument comparing two interpretations of quiet rebellion in The Revolt of "Mother". Weigh the evidence for each and defend the stronger reading in a mature, well-organized essay.

AP (1300 words; Common Core: W.11-12.1, RL.11-12.2): Write a literary argument: develop a defensible thesis about how Mary E. Wilkins Freeman's choices in The Revolt of "Mother" (a recurring element, structure and narration) shape a complex understanding of quiet rebellion, weigh at least one competing reading, and sustain commentary on well-chosen evidence. Do not merely summarize.

College Freshman (1600 words; Common Core: ICC-WC-1.5, ICC-WC-1.4, ICC-WC-1.7): Write a researched essay (4–6 pages) that places The Revolt of "Mother"'s treatment of quiet rebellion in its historical context, using at least two scholarly sources.

College Sophomore (2200 words; Common Core: LeL-C2-W-1, LeL-C2-LIT-1): Write a contextual essay (6–8 pages) on quiet rebellion in The Revolt of "Mother" that reads the story against its genre and period and engages two published critics. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

College Junior (2800 words; Common Core: LeL-C3-W-1, LeL-C3-LIT-1): Write a theoretically informed essay (8–10 pages) on quiet rebellion in The Revolt of "Mother". Name your critical method, apply it closely, and acknowledge its limits. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

College Senior (4000 words; Common Core: LeL-C4-W-1, LeL-C4-LIT-1): Write a research paper (12–15 pages) with an original argument about quiet rebellion in The Revolt of "Mother", engaging at least four scholarly sources in Chicago style. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

Graduate / PhD (6000 words; Common Core: LeL-GR-W-1, LeL-GR-LIT-1): Write a seminar paper (15–20 pages) that intervenes in the critical conversation on quiet rebellion in The Revolt of "Mother", engaging the relevant scholarship and textual history. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

Rubric: Claim · Evidence · Analysis · Organization · Conventions

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